

From Posting Tweets to Keeping the Audience on the Edge of Their Seats

Getting Out There as a Science Communicator

Leen Sevens



All these people really seem to have it together,
and I still have no idea what's going on.







Radio 1
@radio1be

Follow

Tekst begrijpen is moeilijk voor mensen met verstandelijke handicap. Dus ontwikkelde [@LeenSevens](#) een vertaalprogramma naar pictogrammen. Getest door [@frankdeboosere](#) [@ksavjee](#) [@lievenverstrae1](#) en Martine Tanghe [#NieuweFeiten](#)
picto.ccl.kuleuven.be/DemoShowcase.h...

Translate from Dutch

3:37 AM - 8 Jan 2018

2 Retweets 8 Likes

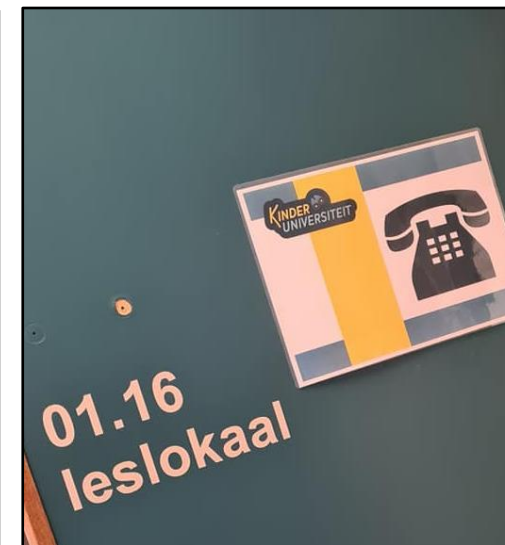
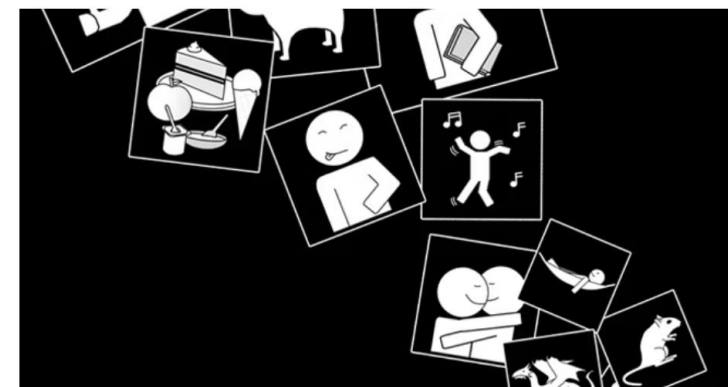


EOS
WETENSCHAP

NIJWSTE NUMMER • NATUUR & MILIEU • TECHNOLOGIE • GEZONDHEID • RUIMTE • NATUURWETENSCHAPPEN • GESCHIEDENIS • PSYCHE & BREIN • BLOGS • PODCAST • AGENDA • BOEKEN

Technologie

Chatten zonder Letters





Overview of today's session

- Exploring different SciComm channels
 - Sailing the Internet seas
 - Conquering the stage - Pitch competitions
 - Better than Tomorrowland! - Festivals and events
 - Taking matters into your own hands - Directly reaching out to stakeholders
- Tips & tricks for beginning science communicators
- Conclusions



What communication channels have you used in the past to communicate about your research?

- Written social media (Twitter, LinkedIn,...) **A**
- Blogs/articles on science communication websites **B**
- Video & audio (YouTube, TikTok, podcasts,...) **C**
- Pitch competitions (Falling Walls Lab, 3 Minute Thesis, Flemish PhD Cup,...) **D**
- Festivals & events (Science Day, Children's University, Nerdland,...) **E**
- Directly reaching out to the media or press office **F**
- Visiting a school/library/museum/... to talk about my research **G**
- None! **H**

🌐 When poll is active, respond at **pollev.com/leensevens**

📱 Text **LEENSEVENS** to **+32 460 20 00 56** once to join

What should we talk about first today?

Sailing the Internet seas

Conquering the stage - Pitch
competitions

Better than Tomorrowland! - Festivals
and events

Taking matters into your own hands –
Directly reaching out to stakeholders

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Start the presentation to see live content. For screen share software, share the entire screen. Get help at pollev.com/app



Sailing the Internet seas

Written Social Media (Twitter/LinkedIn/...)

Create an account, connect, and start sharing!

#AcademicChatter

#AcademicTwitter

#SciComm

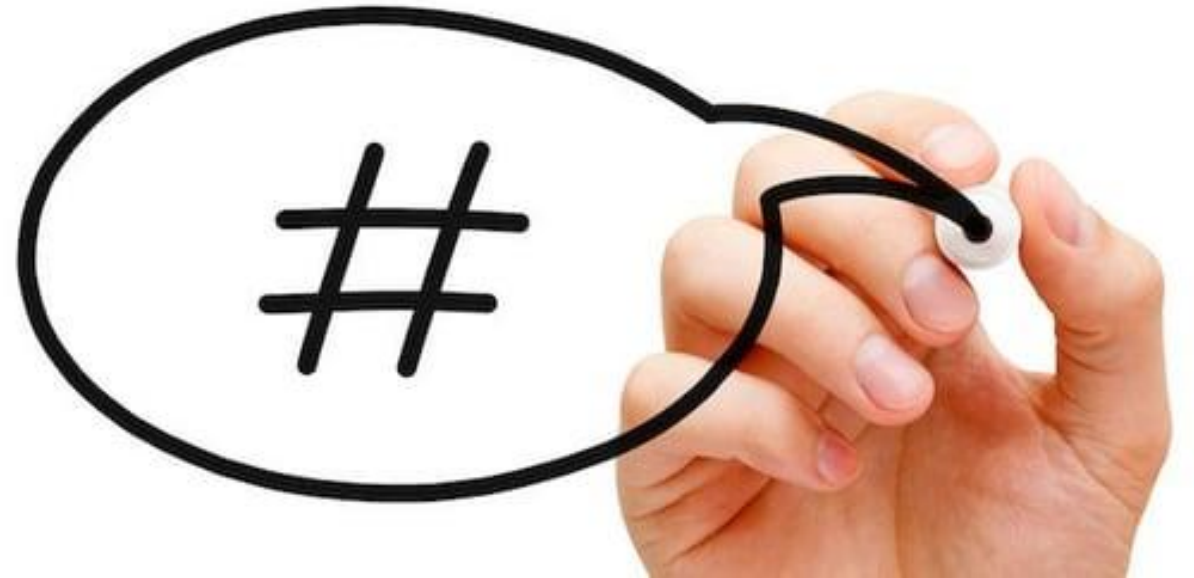
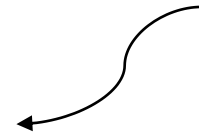
#WomeninSTEM

#AcademicMentalHealth

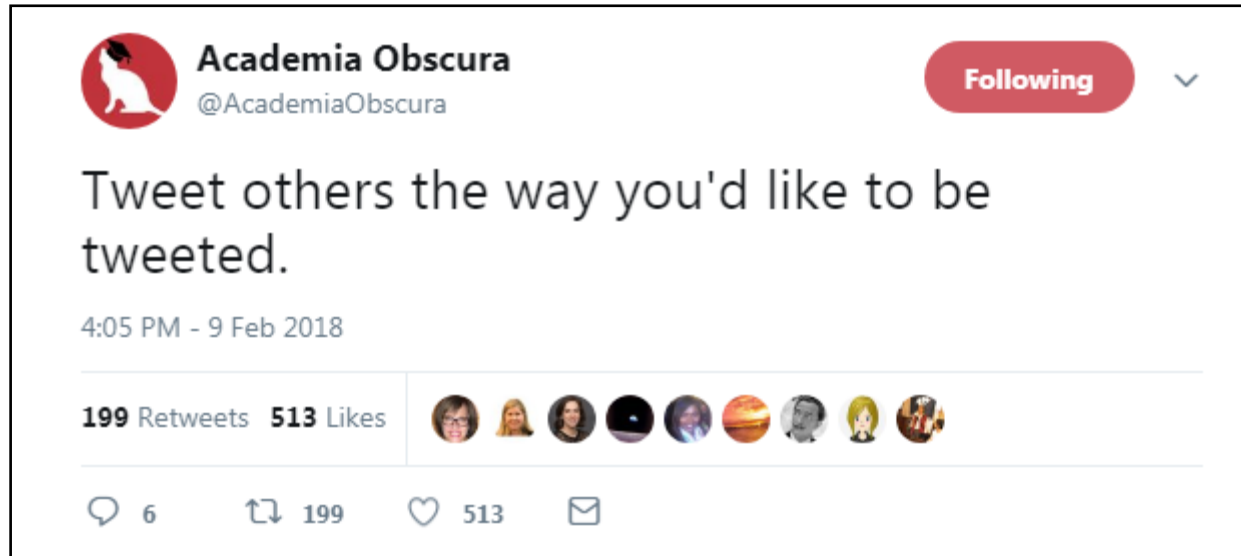
#WomenWhoCode

#Linguistics, #History,...

Useful hashtags



The basic rules...

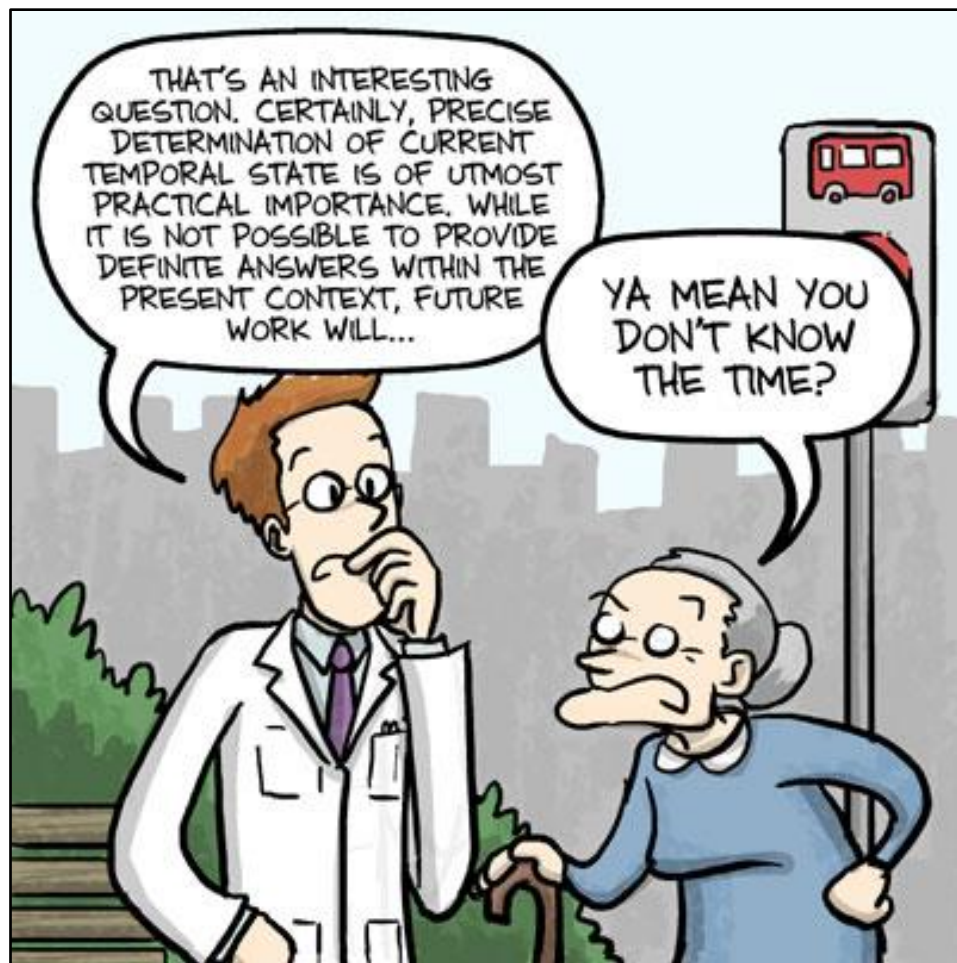


Writer's block?

- Live-tweet conferences, talks and other events (like this one!)
- Direct message people you want to interview, talk to and/or brainstorm with
- Share things you find inspiring
- Offer to answer questions related to particular topics
- Rant and talk about life as a scientist and science communicator



Don't forget: no jargon!



Need inspiration? Feeling inspired?
The #ThesisThread Competition

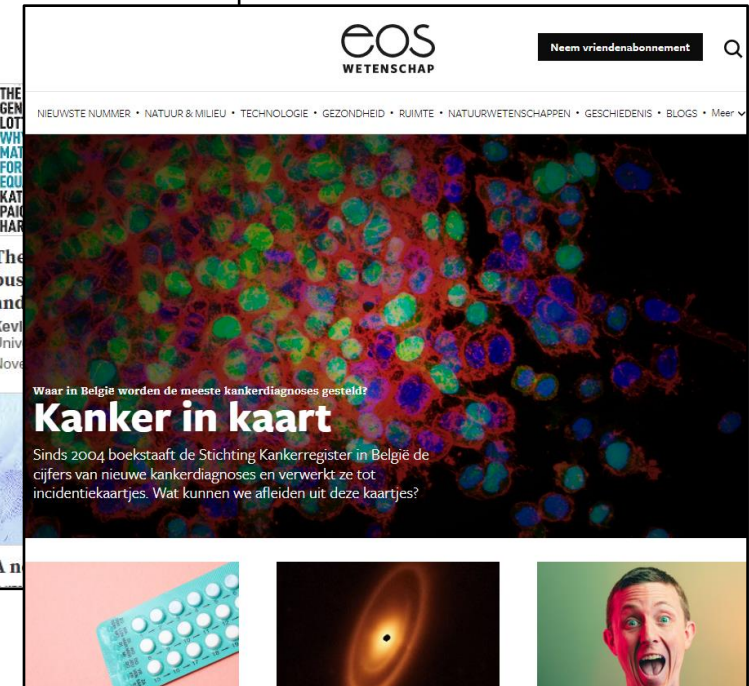
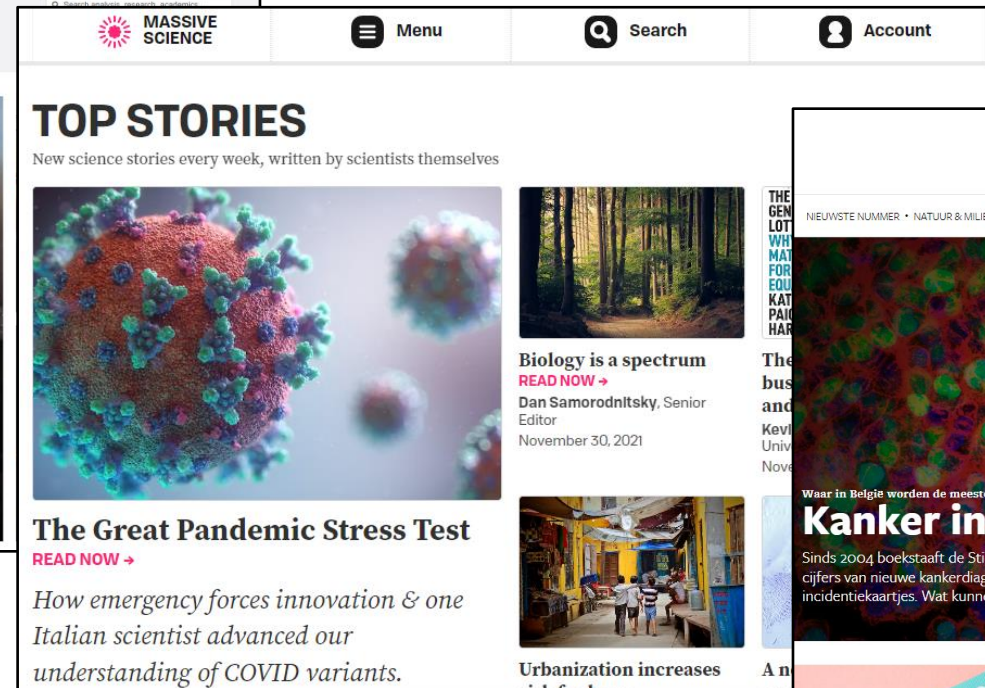
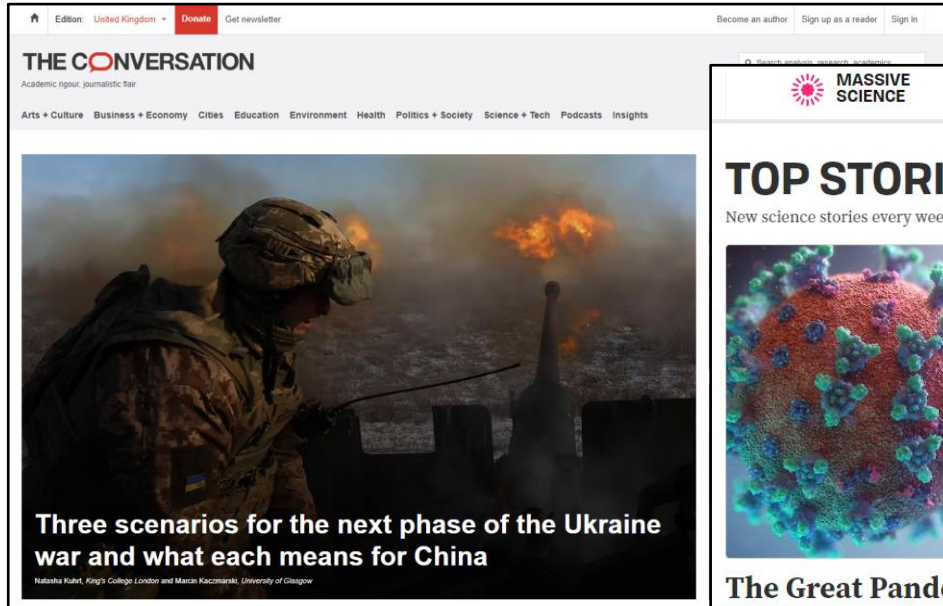
Who? Last-year PhDs &
PhDs who have defended in
the past 6 months
Language? English or Dutch
When? September
URL?

<https://vlir.be/events/thesis-thread/>



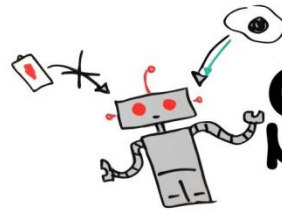
Blogs & science communication websites

Publish an article on The Conversation, Massive Science, The Science Breaker, EOS Magazine,...



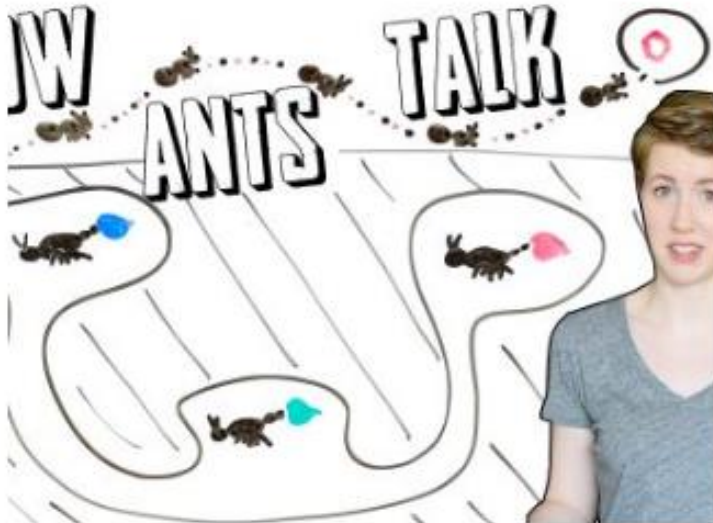
Video & Audio (YouTube/TikTok/Spotify/...)

Create your own science videos and podcasts!



SimpleBiologist

Just like Kate!

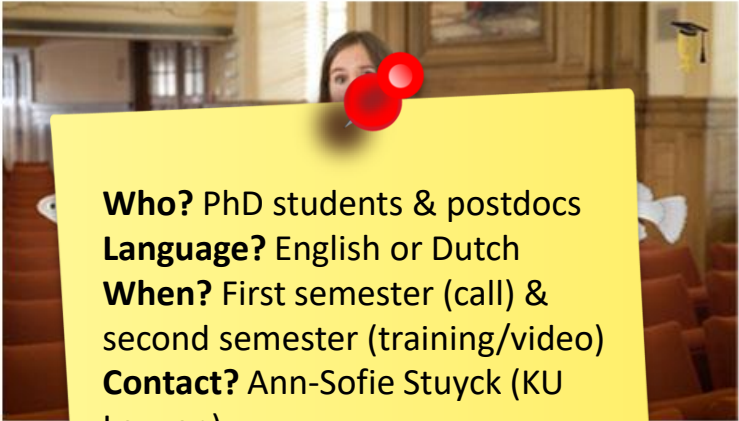


The MutAnts are Here

Posted on [August 27, 2017](#)

Have you ever seen ants walking in a line and wondered how they do it? Scientists have known for a long time that ants use secreted chemicals called pheromones to [...]

[READ MORE](#)



Who? PhD students & postdocs
Language? English or Dutch
When? First semester (call) & second semester (training/video)
Contact? Ann-Sofie Stuyck (KU Leuven)

URL? <https://www.sciencefiguredout.be/>
<https://www.wetenschapuitgedokterd.be/>



Need a little push?
Wetenschap Uitgedokterd
(Science Figured Out)





Conquering the stage
Pitch competitions

Falling Walls Lab

Pitch your research in just 3 minutes!



Who? Students, researchers, postdocs, junior professors

Language? English

When? February (call & training) & March (competition)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/communicatie/wetenschapscommunicatie/voor-onderzoekers/falling-walls-lab/falling-walls-lab-for-candidates>

**FOR CREATORS,
INNOVATORS,
TRAILBLAZERS,
AND VISIONARIES**

De Vlaamse PhD Cup

Extensive media training & a 3-minute pitch

Who? PhDs who have defended in the past two years

Language? Dutch

When? July 7th (deadline for call) & October (training & competition)

URL? <https://www.phdcup.be/>



Three Minute Thesis

Pitch your research in – *guess what?* – 3 minutes!



Who? PhD students & postdocs

Language? English

When? November (call & competition)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/communicatie/wetenschapscommunicatie/voor-onderzoekers/3-minute-thesis/3MinuteThesis>

Wetenschapsbattle (Battle of the Scientists)

Making kids excited about your research



Who? All Researchers

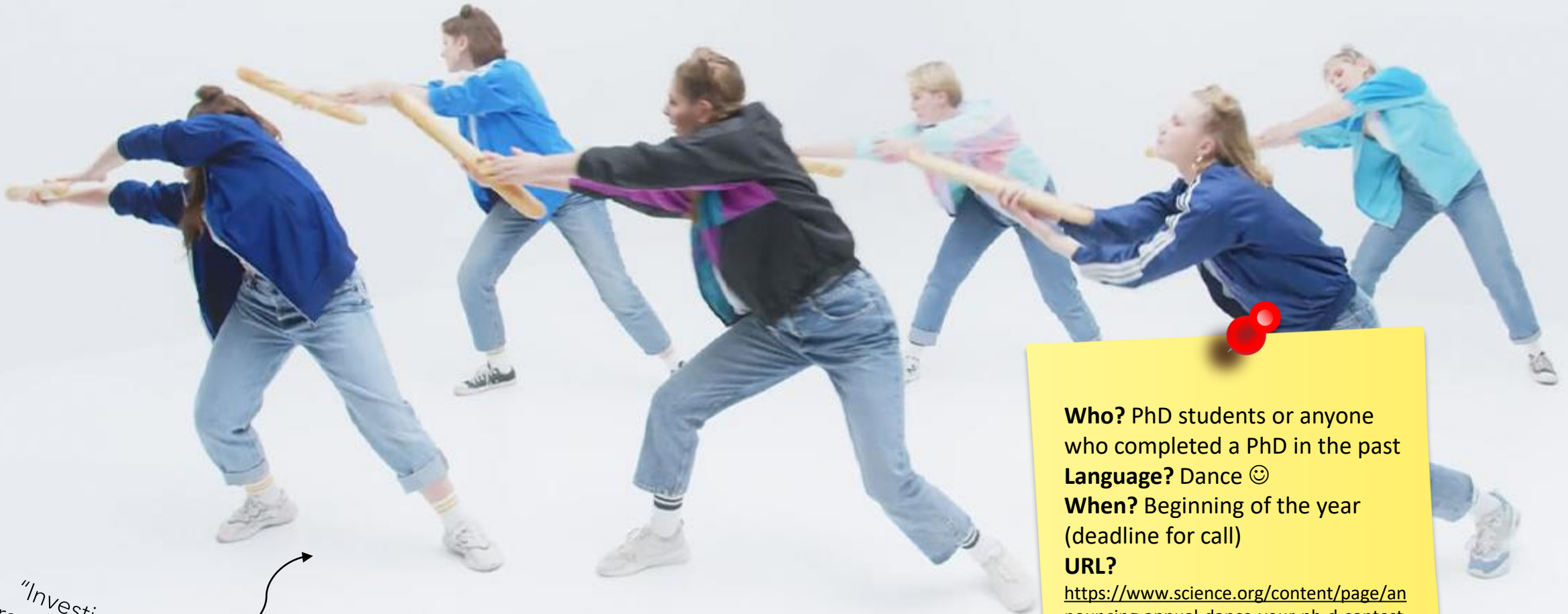
Language? English, Dutch or French

When? November (call) & March (competition)

URL? <https://wetenschapsbattle.be/>

Dance Your PhD

Because words are overrated!



“Investigation of yeast cell
responses to pulsed electric
field treatment”

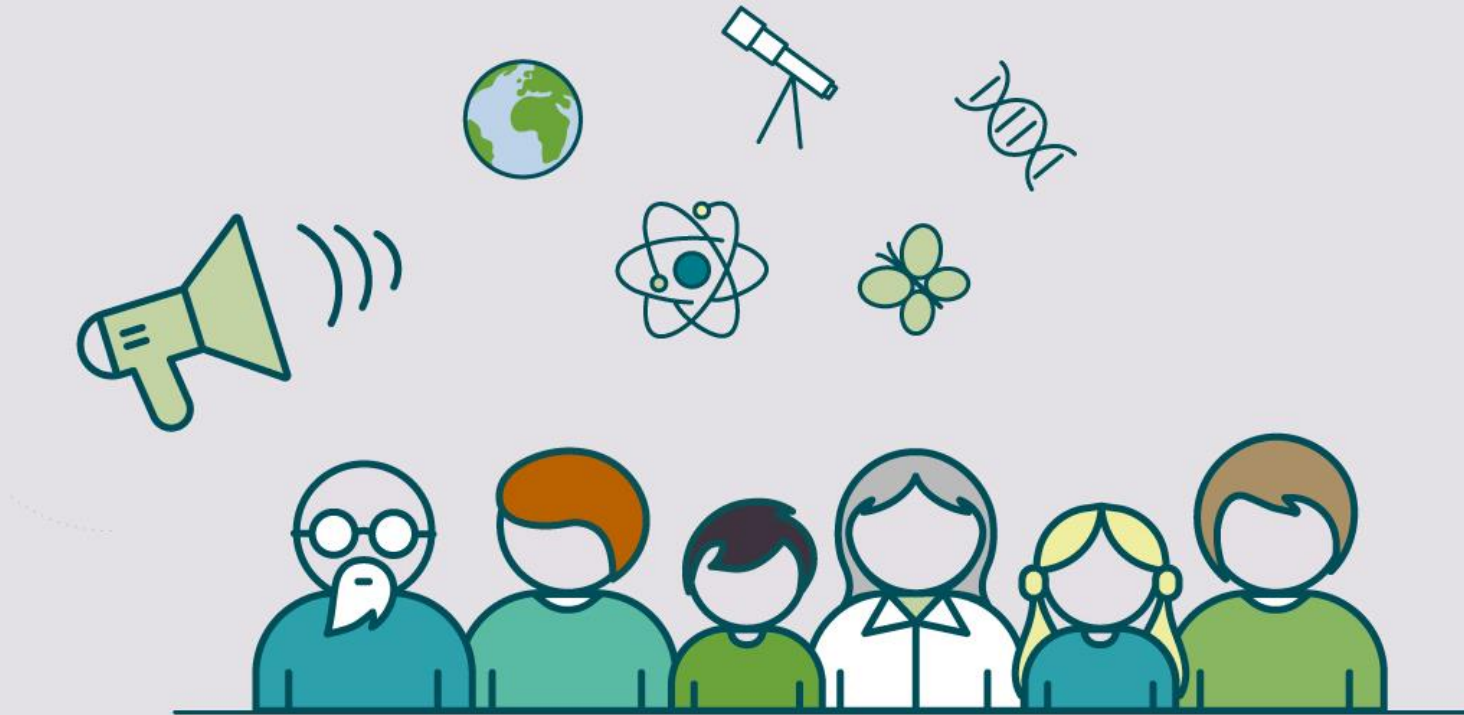
Who? PhD students or anyone
who completed a PhD in the past

Language? Dance 😊

When? Beginning of the year
(deadline for call)

URL?

<https://www.science.org/content/page/announcing-annual-dance-your-ph-d-contest>



Better than Tomorrowland!
Festivals & events

Dag van de Wetenschap (Science Day)

Welcoming a broad audience to our “sacred” research grounds

Who? All researchers

Language? English or Dutch

When? August 15th (deadline for call) & 4th Sunday of November (event)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/events/nl/dag-van-de-wetenschap>



Kinderuniversiteit

Making kids feel like a real university student for one day



Who? All researchers

Language? Dutch

When? October (KULAK: 28th of October)

Contact? Lisa Castro (KU Leuven)
(kinderuniversiteit@kuleuven.be)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/kinderuniversiteit/>

Pint of Science

Beer & research!

Who? All researchers
Language? English or Dutch
When? May
Contact?
belgium@pintofscience.com
URL? <https://www.pintofscience.be/>

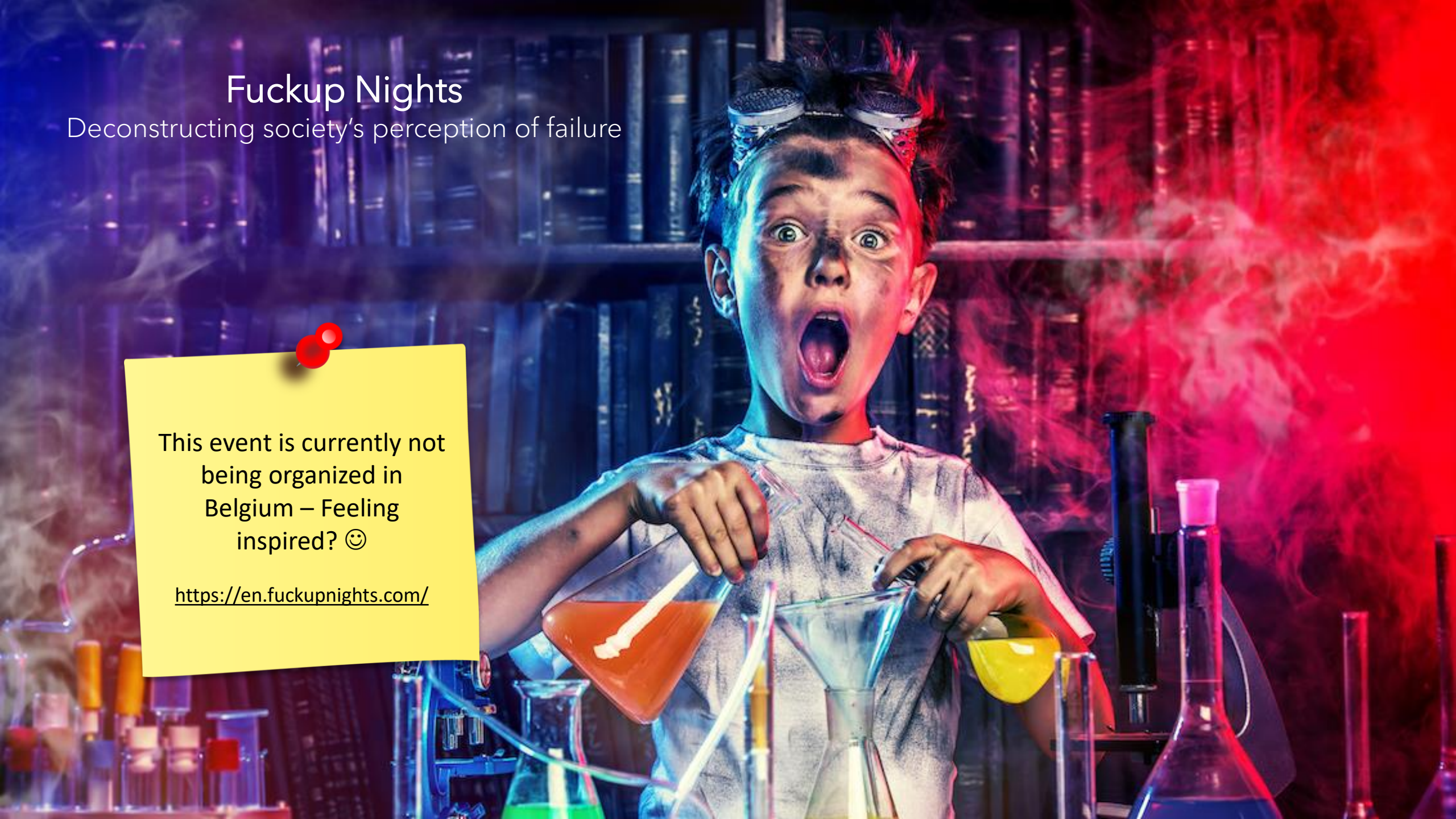


Fuckup Nights

Deconstructing society's perception of failure

This event is currently not
being organized in
Belgium – Feeling
inspired? 😊

<https://en.fuckupnights.com/>



Nerland Festival

Geeks unite!

Who? All researchers

Language? Dutch

When? Autumn (call) & May (festival)

URL?

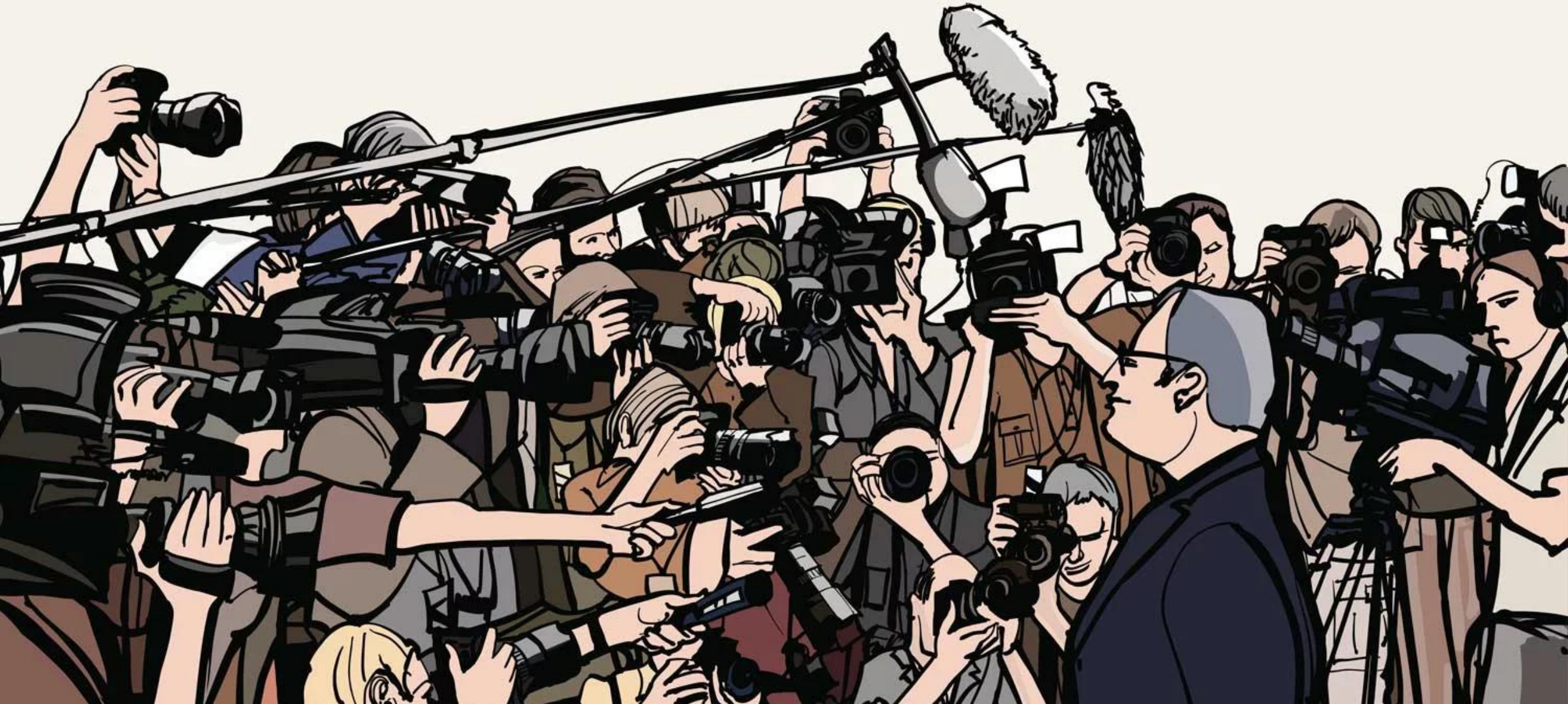
<https://www.nerdlandfestival.be/nl/>





Taking matters into your own hands
Directly reaching out to stakeholders

Reaching out to the media or the university's press office



Visiting schools

Inspiring the professionals of tomorrow



Skype a Scientist

Connect with classrooms across the globe!



Find your perfect match
on:

<https://www.skypeascientist.com>



Tips & tricks for beginning science communicators

- Always prepare for your interviews
- Anticipate questions and prepare bullet points for answers
- Simplify your complicated research by having non-jargon word replacements on hand
- Prepare easy-to-understand analogies ahead of time
- We don't always need to take ourselves seriously to get others to listen 😊
- Know your audience

Learn more about science communication at:



<https://scimingo.eu/nl/scicomm-academy>



<https://www.letstalkscience.be/>



Conclusions



Take-home messages

- The perfect science communication activity for you is the one that you enjoy, that you are good at and that people like you to do
- Be patient, it takes time both to find your voice and to build an audience
- Don't be afraid to promote your work on social media or in your workplace
- Just do it, all it often takes is just a tiny bit of courage!



Thank you!

leen.sevens@kuleuven.be
@leensevens